



Revival Redux

Old Boston is made of red brick, right? Wrong. Much of the historic city is built of a grimmer, grayer, more muscular material: granite. Here are two superb examples. Both have occupied, at different times, the same site at 26 Court Street behind Old City Hall.

The site itself has quite a history. There was a jail here as far back as the 1630s. The superstar prisoner was probably Captain Kidd, the pirate, who paced a cell from 1699 to 1700, when he was shipped off to England to be hanged. And it was there that Nathaniel Hawthorne locked up Hester Prynne in his novel *The Scarlet Letter*.

In 1836, the site acquired the building seen in the old photo. This was the Suffolk County Courthouse. The architect was Solomon Willard, and Willard was a granite junkie. He supervised a quarry in Quincy, and he invented more efficient ways to cut and move granite. He also designed the Bunker Hill Monument and figured out how to build it. Because of Willard, huge blocks of granite became, for decades, the standard for major buildings in Boston.

Willard favored the Greek Revival style, which flourished from about 1820 to 1850. But Suffolk Courthouse only pretended to be a Greek temple. Most of it was just a simple granite box. Only the porch in the foreground, with four huge Doric columns supporting a triangular pediment, looked like a temple. The building wore a Greek mask.

Each 25-ton column was carved from a single stone. The columns were hauled by 65 teams of oxen from Quincy.

The new photo shows the building that replaced the courthouse in 1912: an annex to Old City Hall. The architect was Edward T. P. Graham, and Graham's building looks like Suffolk in drag. Where Suffolk's columns are crisp and severe, those of the annex flower into lavish Corinthian capitals. There's a frosting of ornament everywhere. Scholars call the annex Neoclassical Revival, but maybe it should be Imperial Style. It resembles the self-important buildings of Europe of the same pre-World War era.

Since 1968, when Boston's new City Hall opened, the annex has housed the offices of the Boston School Committee. **BG**

A selection of "Cityscapes" columns and photographs is on exhibit at Panopticon Gallery in the Hotel Commonwealth, 502C Commonwealth Avenue, Boston, until December 3.

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